

BARBARIANS



TO THE ANCIENT GREEKS, all foreigners or outsiders were known as barbarians, but from the 3rd century on, this term was increasingly applied to nomadic mounted tribespeople from Asia, eastern Europe, and parts of Germany, such as the Huns and Goths. Organized into fearsome cavalry armies, these so-called barbarians caused havoc in their search for land, and were finally responsible for the collapse of the western Roman Empire.



Who were the barbarians?

To most Europeans, barbarian tribes included Huns and Avars (from Asia), and Saxons, Vandals, and Goths (from Germany). Huns migrating from Asia into Europe caused fear among the resident Germanic tribes, who then poured in huge numbers across the Roman Empire's frontiers. In a short time, this migration led to the fall of the empire.



Huns made bows and arrows out of strips of bone.

Horse saddle

Hunting on the Steppes
by Chen Chii-Chung (Sung dynasty)

Huns

The Huns were a nomadic Mongol people from the high plains, or steppes, of Central Asia who invaded southeastern Europe in c.370. Fierce in battle and famous for their skill on horseback, they conquered the Ostrogoths and drove the Vandals and other tribes westward.

Under the leadership of Attila they reached their zenith, ravaging the Byzantine Empire and invading Gaul (modern France). In the 5th and 6th centuries, the White Huns, a related people, raided Persia (Iran) and northern India.



Catalaunian Plains

The Huns were deadly in battle as mounted archers. They made short bows of bone, which were light and easy to use while on horseback. They also fought with sabres at close quarters. Under Attila, the Huns were victorious many times, but in 451, they were finally defeated by the Romans and their allies at the Catalaunian Plains, Gaul (now Chalons-sur-Marne, France).

Attila the Hun

Attila (c.406–453) became king of the Huns in 434 jointly with his brother Bleda, whom he murdered in 445. Attila united his people into a vast horde based in Hungary, then waged campaigns to win land and tribute from the Roman and Byzantine empires. Short and crafty, the so-called "Scourge of God" was cruel to his enemies but fair to his own people. He died – possibly of poison – on his wedding night.



Ostrogoths and Visigoths

The Ostrogoths were a Germanic tribe on the Black Sea who were related to the Visigoths from the Danube area. After the Roman Empire fell in 476, the Visigoths adopted Christianity, and translated the Bible from Latin into a "Gothic" script, which was used for centuries in German printing.

Gothic architecture

Many medieval churches and cathedrals were built in the Gothic style. The highly decorative details, such as gargoyles, were believed by Renaissance artists to be "barbarous" when compared with the simplicity of older Roman buildings. So the artists named them after the Gothic tribes that overran Rome.



Notre-Dame gargoyles,
Paris, France



Saxon shoulder clasp

Gold and enamel



Gold and garnet

Etched snake designs

Gold

Mosaic glass

Saxon purse lid

Saxons

"The barbarians drive us to the sea, and the sea drives us back to the barbarians; one way or another we die." So wrote a group of 5th-century Britons to their former masters in Rome. The seafaring barbarians threatening them were Saxons, Angles, and Jutes – Germanic tribes of skilled craftworkers and farmers who conquered and settled stretches of fertile Britain from c.500.

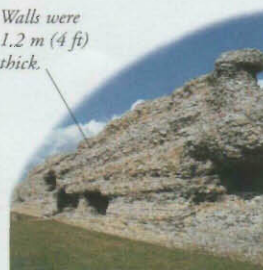


Saxon buckle

Richborough Fort

The Romans built bases at Richborough and elsewhere on the southeastern English coast in the 3rd and 4th centuries. From these forts they could see and try to intercept Saxon raiders.

Walls were
1.2 m (4 ft)
thick.



British ships destroying Chinese junks

Barbarians in the East

People beyond Europe also believed that outsiders were barbarians. The 18th-century Chinese looked down on "foreign devils", and insisted that all trade between China and the west took place only in the port of Canton. The Japanese actually stopped any foreigners from entering Japan for more than 200 years, until 1854.

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